
REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL

Managed Cloud Infrastructure & Cybersecurity Services

Reference Number:	RFP-GOV-2024-0147
Issuing Organisation:	Department of Digital Infrastructure, Government of Aravand
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1. Introduction & Background

The Department of Digital Infrastructure (hereinafter 'the Department' or 'the Contracting Authority') invites suitably qualified vendors to submit proposals for the design, deployment, and ongoing management of a national Managed Cloud Infrastructure and Cybersecurity Services platform. This initiative is part of the Government of Aravand's Digital Transformation Programme 2024–2028.

The successful vendor will be responsible for providing a highly available, secure, and scalable cloud environment capable of supporting up to 50 government ministries, approximately 200,000 end users, and a peak throughput of 10,000 concurrent API transactions per second.

This RFP is issued under the Public Procurement Act 2022 and all submissions must comply with the associated Procurement Regulations. Failure to meet any Mandatory requirement will result in automatic disqualification of the bid.

2. Scope of Work

The scope of this contract encompasses the following service areas:

- Design, provisioning, and ongoing management of a multi-region cloud infrastructure
- Implementation of a Zero-Trust security architecture across all government workloads
- 24/7 Security Operations Centre (SOC) monitoring and incident response
- Managed backup, disaster recovery, and business continuity services
- Identity and Access Management (IAM) including Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)
- Compliance management and audit support for ISO 27001 and SOC 2 Type II
- End-user training, onboarding documentation, and a dedicated service desk
- Monthly performance reporting covering all agreed Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

3. Technical Specifications & Requirements

3.1 Infrastructure & Performance

The vendor must provision infrastructure across a minimum of two geographically separate data centres within the territory of Aravand. The platform must support elastic scaling to accommodate traffic spikes of up to 300% above baseline without degradation of service.

The vendor must maintain a minimum system uptime of 99.9% measured on a rolling monthly basis. Planned maintenance windows are permitted but must not exceed four hours per calendar month and shall be scheduled outside of core government working hours (08:00–18:00 local time).

Application Programming Interface (API) response times must not exceed 200 milliseconds at the 95th percentile under normal operating load. The vendor must provide real-time performance dashboards accessible to the Department's technical team.

The system is expected to support a minimum of 200,000 concurrent user sessions during peak periods. Load testing results demonstrating this capacity must be submitted as part of the proposal.

3.2 Security & Encryption

All data at rest and in transit must be encrypted using AES-256 or an equivalent FIPS 140-2 validated algorithm. The vendor must implement end-to-end encryption for all inter-service communications within the platform.

The vendor must implement Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) for all privileged user accounts and shall enforce MFA as the default authentication mechanism for all government end-user accounts within six months of go-live.

All security configurations, firewall rules, and access control policies must be reviewed and validated by an independent third party at least once every twelve months. The vendor shall provide the Department with the resulting audit reports within 30 days of completion.

The vendor must conduct automated vulnerability scanning of all platform components on a weekly basis and must remediate any Critical (CVSS score ≥ 9.0) vulnerabilities within 72 hours of detection. High severity vulnerabilities (CVSS 7.0–8.9) must be remediated within 14 calendar days.

If applicable, the vendor should implement a Hardware Security Module (HSM) for cryptographic key management to ensure the highest level of key protection.

3.3 Support & Service Levels

The vendor must provide a dedicated 24/7 technical support service with a guaranteed initial response time of no more than 30 minutes for Priority 1 (Critical) incidents and no more than 2 hours for Priority 2 (High) incidents. All support interactions must be logged in a certified ITSM platform.

A dedicated Technical Account Manager (TAM) must be assigned to the Department and must be available during standard business hours. The TAM shall conduct a minimum of one formal service review meeting per month with the Department's contract management team.

The vendor must provide a self-service web portal through which the Department can raise incidents, track resolution progress, access knowledge base articles, and view real-time SLA performance metrics.

3.4 Backup & Disaster Recovery

The vendor must implement automated daily backups of all government data. Full system backups shall be retained for a minimum of 90 days. Point-in-time recovery must be available for all relational database workloads with a granularity of no more than 15 minutes.

The vendor must maintain a documented and tested Disaster Recovery Plan. The Recovery Time Objective (RTO) must not exceed 4 hours and the Recovery Point Objective (RPO) must not exceed 1 hour for Tier-1 critical government workloads. The DR plan must be tested and validated at least twice per year.

4. Legal Compliance & Certification Requirements

4.1 Information Security Standards

The vendor must hold a valid ISO/IEC 27001:2022 certification issued by an accredited certification body. A copy of the current certificate must be included with the proposal submission. Vendors whose certification is due for renewal within six months of the proposal deadline must provide evidence of the renewal process.

The vendor must also hold SOC 2 Type II attestation covering Security, Availability, and Confidentiality trust service criteria. The most recent SOC 2 report (no older than 12 months) must be submitted with the proposal.

All data processing activities must comply with the Aravand Data Protection Act 2021 and, where applicable, the European Union General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). The vendor must appoint a named Data Protection Officer (DPO) and provide the DPO's contact details in the proposal.

4.2 Personnel & Background Checks

All personnel assigned to work on this contract, whether directly employed or subcontracted, must have undergone a Government Security Vetting (GSV) background check to a minimum of Baseline Personnel Security Standard (BPSS) level prior to commencing work. Personnel requiring access to OFFICIAL-SENSITIVE classified systems must hold Security Check (SC) clearance.

The vendor must maintain a current list of all cleared personnel and must notify the Department within 24 hours if any cleared individual's status changes or their employment is terminated.

4.3 Insurance Requirements

The vendor must maintain, for the duration of the contract, the following minimum insurance coverage:

Insurance Type	Minimum Coverage
Professional Indemnity Insurance	GBP 10,000,000 per occurrence
Cyber Liability Insurance	GBP 5,000,000 per occurrence
Public Liability Insurance	GBP 5,000,000 per occurrence
Employer's Liability Insurance	GBP 10,000,000 (statutory minimum)

Evidence of all insurance policies must be submitted with the proposal. Policies must name 'The Government of Aravand' as an additional insured party.

4.4 Subcontracting

The vendor must disclose the use of any subcontractors whose individual contribution to the contract value exceeds 10%. Each such subcontractor must independently meet the insurance and security vetting requirements set out in this RFP. The Department reserves the right to reject any proposed subcontractor.

5. Financial & Commercial Terms

5.1 Pricing & Payment

All pricing must be submitted in Aravand Pounds Sterling (APS) and must remain fixed for the initial 36-month term of the contract. Any proposed price variation mechanism for subsequent years must be clearly documented and linked to an independent economic index.

Payment shall be made within 30 days of the receipt of a valid invoice. Invoices must be submitted monthly in arrears and must include a detailed breakdown of services rendered, units consumed, and any applicable taxes. The vendor must accept electronic funds transfer as the sole payment method.

The vendor must not levy any charges that are not explicitly stated in the agreed Schedule of Rates. Any request for additional payment outside the contracted scope must be submitted in writing and approved by the Department's contract manager before the work commences.

5.2 Financial Standing

The vendor must demonstrate satisfactory financial standing. Proposals must include audited financial statements for the most recent three financial years. The vendor must have an annual turnover of no less than APS 20 million and must not be subject to any insolvency proceedings.

A Performance Bond equivalent to 10% of the total annual contract value must be provided by the vendor's bank within 30 days of contract award.

5.3 Liquidated Damages

In the event that the vendor fails to meet the agreed SLA targets in any given calendar month, liquidated damages shall be applied at a rate of 2% of the monthly contract value for each percentage point (or part thereof) by which the uptime falls below 99.9%. The maximum aggregate liquidated damages in any 12-month period shall be capped at 15% of the annual contract value.

6. Operational Requirements

6.1 Training & Documentation

The vendor must deliver a comprehensive training programme for up to 500 government IT administrators and end-users within 60 days of the go-live date. Training must be available in both classroom and online (self-paced) formats.

The vendor shall provide full technical documentation including system architecture diagrams, operational runbooks, API reference guides, and security configuration baselines. All documentation must be maintained in an online portal and updated within 15 working days of any significant platform change.

6.2 Reporting

The vendor must submit a detailed Monthly Service Report (MSR) to the Department no later than the 10th working day of the following month. Each MSR must include: uptime statistics, incident volumes and resolution times, security event summaries, capacity utilisation trends, and a forward-looking risk register.

The vendor must provide an annual Continuous Service Improvement (CSI) plan identifying at least three measurable service improvements to be delivered in the coming year.

6.3 Environmental & Sustainability

The vendor should demonstrate a credible pathway to achieving net-zero carbon emissions for all data centre operations supporting this contract by 2030. Where possible, the vendor shall use renewable energy sources for all infrastructure powering government workloads.

The vendor is expected to submit an annual Environmental Impact Report covering energy consumption, carbon emissions, and water usage associated with service delivery under this contract.

7. Master Requirements Checklist

The table below summarises all mandatory and key conditional requirements. Vendors must explicitly address each item in their proposal. Any Mandatory requirement that is not addressed will result in disqualification.

Req #	Requirement	Category	Priority
R01	The vendor must maintain a minimum system uptime of 99.9% measured monthly.	Technical	Mandatory
R02	The vendor must provision infrastructure across a minimum of two geographically separate data centres.	Technical	Mandatory
R03	API response times must not exceed 200ms at the 95th percentile under normal load.	Technical	Mandatory
R04	All data at rest and in transit must be encrypted using AES-256 or FIPS 140-2 equivalent.	Security	Mandatory
R05	The vendor must implement Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) for all privileged accounts.	Security	Mandatory
R06	Critical vulnerabilities (CVSS >= 9.0) must be remediated within 72 hours of detection.	Security	Mandatory
R07	The vendor must provide 24/7 technical support with P1 response within 30 minutes.	Support	Mandatory
R08	The vendor must hold a valid ISO/IEC 27001:2022 certification.	Legal	Mandatory
R09	The vendor must hold SOC 2 Type II attestation (no older than 12 months).	Legal	Mandatory
R10	All data processing must comply with the Aravand Data Protection Act 2021 and GDPR.	Legal	Mandatory
R11	All personnel must hold BPSS clearance before commencing work.	Legal	Mandatory
R12	The vendor must maintain Professional Indemnity Insurance of GBP 10 million.	Financial	Mandatory
R13	The vendor must maintain Cyber Liability Insurance of GBP 5 million.	Financial	Mandatory
R14	Payment shall be made within 30 days of valid invoice receipt.	Financial	Mandatory
R15	The vendor must not levy any charges outside the agreed Schedule of Rates.	Financial	Mandatory
R16	The RTO for Tier-1 workloads must not exceed 4 hours; RPO must not exceed 1 hour.	Technical	Mandatory
R17	The vendor must submit a Monthly Service Report by the 10th working day of each month.	Operational	Mandatory

Req #	Requirement	Category	Priority
R18	The vendor must deliver training for up to 500 users within 60 days of go-live.	Operational	Mandatory
R19	All documentation must be updated within 15 working days of any platform change.	Operational	Mandatory
R20	If applicable, vendor should implement HSM for cryptographic key management.	Security	Conditional
R21	The vendor should demonstrate a net-zero carbon pathway for data centre operations by 2030.	Sustainability	Conditional
R22	The vendor is expected to submit an annual Environmental Impact Report.	Sustainability	Conditional
R23	The system is expected to support 200,000 concurrent user sessions.	Technical	Conditional

8. Submission Requirements & Evaluation Criteria

8.1 Proposal Structure

All proposals must be structured as follows:

- Executive Summary (max 3 pages)
- Company Profile, Financial Statements, and Certifications
- Technical Proposal — addressing all requirements in Section 3
- Security Proposal — addressing all requirements in Sections 3.2 and 4.1
- Implementation Plan and Project Timeline
- Service Management Framework and SLA documentation
- Training and Documentation Plan
- Pricing — Schedule of Rates and Total Cost of Ownership
- References — minimum three comparable contracts in the past five years

8.2 Evaluation Criteria

Criterion	Weighting
Technical Compliance & Architecture	35%
Security Posture & Certifications	25%
Commercial Pricing & Value for Money	20%
Service Management & SLA Commitments	10%
Sustainability & Environmental Impact	5%
Implementation Plan & Risk Management	5%

8.3 Key Dates

Milestone	Date
RFP Issue Date	15 January 2024
Clarification Questions Deadline	29 January 2024
Clarification Responses Published	5 February 2024
Proposal Submission Deadline	28 February 2024 at 17:00 local time
Evaluation Period	March 2024
Preferred Bidder Notification	15 April 2024

Contract Award	1 May 2024
Expected Go-Live Date	1 September 2024

All enquiries must be submitted in writing to: procurement@digital.gov.aravand. Verbal enquiries will not be accepted. This document is issued subject to the terms of the Non-Disclosure Agreement provided separately.